



THE WHARTON SCHOOL

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT WHARTON

Wharton Business School is part of the elite “HSW” trinity. The entrepreneurial community has surged in the past six years, and the construction of a six-story entrepreneurial hub, Tangen Hall, offers further evidence of the ways Wharton continues to evolve beyond its roots in finance and drive entrepreneurial innovation. The business school’s success in incubating industry disruptors prompted Inc. magazine to dub the school “the spiritual center of the DTC startup movement.”

Women have made up at least 40% of the class for the last seven years. And its newly appointed dean, Erika James, will be first woman and person of color in its storied history. The quality of admitted students is also on the rise, if measured by the average 730 GMAT score of the incoming class.

The introduction of a Team Based Discussion component to the MBA admissions has been well received by participants, and showcases the interaction and inclusive values that are a far cry from the outdated stereotype of a competitive student body. The school's improving yield indicates that that more applicants are saying ‘yes’ to Wharton.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

General Management, Finance, Health Care, Entrepreneurship, Real Estate, Nonprofit/Social Responsibility, International Management, Economics, Big Data. Over 200 electives on offer.

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	3	3	2	5	6	6	2	6
Financial Times	3	3	3	2	4	3	2	3
Forbes	-	4	-	7	-	1	-	5
The Economist	10	10	9	8	12	-	4	4
US News	3	3	1	3	4	2	3	1

CLASS OF 2021

Number of Applicants	6245
MBA Class Size	862
Yield	67%
Total Tuition	\$157,896

ADMISSIONS

Avg Work Experience	5 Years
Avg GMAT	730
Avg GPA	3.6
Admissions Selectivity	12%

POST-MBA CAREERS

Financial Services	36.9%
Consulting	25%
Technology	14.9%
Consumer Products	6.2%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

McKinsey, BCG, Bain, Deloitte, Amazon, Apple, Goldman Sachs, Google

AVERAGE BASE SALARY: US\$135,716

EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS: 98.4%

*Rankings are relative to other U.S. business schools. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR WHARTON APPLICATION

BY DR. JUDITH SILVERMAN HODARA

Judith served as a core member of admissions committees at the University of Pennsylvania for almost two decades, most recently as Acting Director at the Wharton School's MBA Program. She was also an Associate Director in the Office of Undergraduate Admissions at the University of Pennsylvania.



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1

DEMONSTRATE YOUR TEAM ORIENTATION

One of the common stereotypes is that Wharton is an “eat or be eaten” kind of environment. Contrary to popular belief, uber-competitive Wharton is actually home to an extremely collaborative and team-oriented learning environment. The utilization of learning clusters, cohorts, and teams (you may work with 15+ over your time in the program) provide a platform for collaboration and learning to lead through teamwork. Accordingly, your application needs to reflect your ability to actively contribute and thrive in these settings. Individuals who present themselves as lacking a team-orientation or having a leadership style that is closed, rather than facilitative, will be at a disadvantage in terms of being invited to interview and ultimately being granted admission.

BALANCE YOUR PERSONAL & PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

2

Wharton does look at each applicant file holistically understanding that what you do for a living is not who you are or what you will bring to the community. You certainly would not want someone to consider you only by your profession, so it's a good idea to use some balance within the framework of your application. Your essay examples should reflect things that the committee may not know about you from outside the workplace, in addition to showcasing your professional skills. If you can keep in mind that you are a sum of about 10,000 parts, and show that in the application, the admissions officers will see that passion and connection too.

3

CONVEY YOUR INTEREST IN WHARTON

Choosing to focus on a particular field of interest in your application is key. Of course, applicants have a variety of interests that they intend to pursue during their MBA. However, in the application it may not be a good idea to be a generalist. Therefore you may want to speak specifically about a professor or a class or a club that interests you, and have them all be connected, so that there is a theme to your writing. With 200 other electives and an incredibly rich student life there are any number of ways to immerse yourself in the MBA experience so think about how you can contribute and make a difference.

ADCOM'S VIEW OF NON-TRADITIONAL BACKGROUNDS

4

Wharton actively encourages applicants coming from non-traditional backgrounds to apply to the school. In addition to bringing a wealth of diversity to the classroom discussion from an industry perspective, applicants from this sector have often also had non-business undergraduate academic interests. This combination helps to add to the energy of the classroom and club interactions. With the breadth of the University of Pennsylvania's graduate programs, where students can take up to 4 classes outside of the Wharton program and receive credit, it is not surprising that many Wharton students take classes in other related fields that would further their career paths in non-profit work, such as at the School of Education or School of Social Policy and Practice.

5

PRESENT YOUR CAREER PLAN

It's important within the context of the application process to show that you have a career path in mind. Students who indicate that they have "so many ideas that they don't know where to start" come across as unfocused and non-directed.

The Wharton Vice Dean once famously said, "If we only granted diplomas to those of you who had followed your suggested career paths from your applications, no one would actually graduate!" The beauty of a transformational business school education is that it gives you tremendous exposure to possibilities on a professional and personal level. However, Wharton admissions officers want to ensure that you can create a viable path to follow and that you enter the program with a sense of purpose. Business school has been likened to drinking water from a fire-hose, and those who come in with no plan at all are frequently hosed down by the blast. It is advisable to give as much detail as you can about next steps in your career, showcasing that you understand what the Wharton program will allow you to do along the way.

ESSAY ANALYSIS

In its introduction to its two required essays, Wharton states, "The Admissions Committee wants get to know you on both a professional and personal level" - and it really means it.



ESSAY 1. "What do you hope to gain from a Wharton MBA?" (500 words)

This, of course, is the opportunity to connect your powerful and coherent career vision within the context of how the Wharton MBA – in particular – will set you up for success. In essence, Wharton is asking what you'll get out of being there.

ESSAY 2. "Taking into consideration your background—personal, professional, and/or academic—how do you plan to make specific, meaningful contributions to the Wharton community?" (400 words)

If the first question is asking what you'll get out of Wharton, the second question is getting at this: What will Wharton get in return? The admissions office wants to understand your 'origin story' and how it informs the next steps of your leadership journey.

The specificity of the new question's wording signals that you should connect the dots for the admissions committee between where you are coming from and where you are heading. The challenge is to do so in 400 words, which requires both profound self-awareness and profound understanding of the community you're hoping to join.

The new essay question invites you to go deeper into clarifying how elements of your identity and background shape your awareness and why it matters going forward. Don't just reinforce a link to how your background will 'aid in my teamwork skills,' or how you've developed better communication skills, but share specifics with your reader that go deeper into who you are, what makes you unique and what you offer.

FINAL THOUGHTS

INTERVIEW - TEAM BASED DISCUSSION

In 2012, the Wharton Admissions office partnered with the Wharton Innovation group to launch a new evaluation method, the Team Based Discussion (TBD). If you are invited to interview, you will participate in a TBD with 5-6 other applicants during your scheduled session. The TBD will allow you the opportunity to interact with your fellow applicants through discourse involving real-world business scenarios, which will highlight how you approach and analyze specific situations. Your discussion will have a prompt and a purpose, and you will work towards a tangible outcome with your group. The TBD is additive and does not replace the opportunity for an individual exchange: There will be time allotted for a short one-on-one conversation with a member of the Admissions staff during the interview.

For specific insights and tips on this year's TBD, view Judith's article "[8 Tips for Your Tangen Hall Pitch](#)"

COVID-19

For the latest updates about how COVID-19 is impacting admissions and programming at the Wharton School and all top MBA programs, please visit our [blog](#).

DEADLINES & DATES

	APPLICATION DEADLINE	INTERVIEW INVITATIONS	FINAL DECISIONS
Round 1	September 15, 2020	October 28 2020	December 16, 2020
Round 2	January 5, 2021	February 11, 2021	March 23, 2021
Round 3	March 31, 2020	April 15, 2021	May 11, 2021



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

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